

587 CE

VISIGOTHIC KING OF SPAIN CONVERTS TO CATHOLICISM

The Visigoths, previously adherents of the Arian form of Christianity popular among Germanic groups, adopted Catholicism when their king Reccared converted in 587 CE. The new creed was proclaimed at a Council at Toledo in 589. Despite sporadic uprisings against the new religious policies, it helped integrate Visigoths and Romans and lent the support of the Catholic Church in strengthening the Visigothic monarchy.



◁ Baptism of the
Visigoths in Spain



593 CE

PRINCE SHOTOKU BECOMES REGENT OF JAPAN

After his aunt Suiko became empress of Japan, Shotoku Taishi was chosen to act as regent by the leader of the powerful Soga clan. He ruled wisely, cementing strong links with China and establishing a Chinese-style bureaucratic system with a hierarchy of ranks. He introduced the Seventeen-Article Constitution – a moral code for the ruling class – and promoted Buddhism, building great temples including the Hōryū-ji in Ikaruga.

◁ Prince Shotoku

599 CE

**570 CE Birth of the
Prophet Muhammad**
in the western Arabian
town of Mecca

**597 CE St Augustine arrives
in Kent** on a mission sent by
Pope Gregory I to convert the
Anglo-Saxons

589 CE

CHINA UNIFIED

In 581 CE, a court official, Yang Jian, overthrew the Northern Zhou dynasty and established the Sui. As Emperor Wen, he secured the north, then invaded southern China, defeating the Chen dynasty and capturing its capital Nanjing. With China united in 589 CE after three centuries, he embarked on schemes such as building the Grand Canal, the expense of which contributed to his dynasty's collapse within 30 years.



△ Emperor Wen and boats on the Grand Canal